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## **Culture Wars, Religion, and the Postmodern Sacred**

Michael Strynick

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a review of *One Nation Under God?: Religion and American Culture* (1999), edited by Marjorie Garber and Rebecca L. Walkowitz. (New York: Routledge, 1999); \$16.00 and *Para/Inquiry: Postmodern Religion and Culture*, by Victor Taylor. (New York: Routledge, 2000); \$25.00.

Michael Strynick  
Wake Forest University

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During the 1980s and 1990s, Americans saw their country torn apart over issues of 'political correctness,' the right-wing rhetorical hot button used to discredit a more liberal appreciation of our nation's multiculturalism." The so-called culture wars of the last two decades made evident the deep ideological divides that exist in this country over issues of race, gender, ethnicity, and sexual orientation.' Two recent books, both published by Routledge, examine the way in which religion and spirituality has been part of the fray.' *One Nation Under God?: Religion and American Culture* (1999), edited by Marjorie Garber and Rebecca L. Walkowitz, investigates, in fifteen separate but complementary essays, the practical effects of these culture wars on religion.' The theoretical implications of a decidedly postmodern outlook on religion and culture are examined in Victor Taylor's *Para/Inquiry: Postmodern Religion and Culture* (2000).

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**Michael Strynick** earned his Ph.D. in 1994 from SUNY Binghamton's Program in Philosophy, Literature, and the Theory of Criticism. He currently teaches in the Department of English at Wake Forest University, and has held previous appointments at Davidson College, the University of Wisconsin-Eau Claire, Kent State University, and Georgia Tech. His articles appear in journals such as *Cultural Critique*, *Romanic Review*, and *South Atlantic Review*, and he also contributed several entries to the forthcoming *Routledge Encyclopedia of Postmodernism*. His essay "Emerson, Slavery, and the Evolution of Self-Reliance" will appear in *The Emerson Dilemma: Essays on Emerson and Social Reform*, ed. T. Gregory Garvey (Georgia, 2001), and "The American Postcolonial Condition: Decolonization in Alice Walker's *The Color Purple*" will appear in *Jailbreaks and Re-creations: Resentencing the Other in Colonial and Postcolonial Discourse*, ed. J. A. Wainwright and Muhsin Jassim al-Mussawi. His own book, *The Politics of Community*, will be part of the Series on Critical Studies in the Humanities (Davies, 2001).

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